

DCD 303 Q1 Fall 2025: Sound & Motion Methods: Sonic Storytelling Fall 2025

Tuesdays and Thursdays 3:05 – 4:20 pm (Edwards, 106)

Instructor: Dr. Gayas Eapen

Location: 106, Edwards Building

Office Hours: Tuesdays and Thursdays 1:30 pm – 3pm or by appointment

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Catalog Description: An intermediate course that provides students both an overview of digital video and audio technologies in humanities projects, and an opportunity to build practical skill sets in utilizing these technologies. This course focuses not only on how the use of digital audio and video has evolved in humanities disciplines and humanities-centered interdisciplinary research, but also explores basic methods and techniques for creating digital audio and video in humanities projects that will allow students to build practical skill sets.

Course Description (Fall 2025): In this edition of Sound and Motion methods we will focus on sonic storytelling as both a skill and an experience, a means to comprehend, the world around us. The primary goal of the course is to both produce a feature and learn production skills but to advance our understanding of sound as a phenomenon and how it interacts with how we tell stories, how we listen and perceive the world, how we experience and understand our bodies and how knowledge is generated and circulated. We will engage with the work of sound producers, ethnomusicologists, podcasters, documentarians, and musicians to engage with sound as a broad phenomenon.

Course objectives:

This course will equip students to:

- + **Understand**, capture, and analyze sonic environments creatively
- + **Learn** to record sounds using digital recorders and edit digital editing software
- + **Engage** with experimental tools to analyze commercial and surveillance practices of machine listening
- + **Analyze** site-specific and cultural sonic environments by engaging with global examples
- + **Familiarize** oneself with key artists, scholars, and research priorities within sound studies, machine learning and AI, and sensory and affect studies.
- + **Build** thoughtful and meaningful research-oriented projects that utilize up-to-date tools, software, and techniques

Required Readings/Media

Feld, Stephen. Acoustemology in *Keywords in Sound*

Feld, Stephen. Voices in the Rainforest. Documentary Educational Resources.

Rice, Tom. Listening in *Keywords in Sound*

Cosmic Visions and The Ways of Knowing. In *The World According to Sound*

<https://www.theworldaccordingtosound.org>

Machine Listening Project. machinelisting.exposed

Malcolm Ogden; LEGOified Sound: On the Labor and Leisure of LEGO White Noise. *Resonance* 1

June 2023; 4 (2): 158–175. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1525/res.2023.4.2.158>

[Film] The Last Angel of History (John Akomfrah) - Legendado.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gcbSUwPjass>

[Podcast] *Ways of Hearing* Episode 2.

Secondary Readings (Optional)

Idhe, Don. Auditory Dimension. In *Sound Studies Reader*; Explore: Sonic Street Technologies (ERC-SST) project

Larkin, Brian. (2014) Techniques of Inattention. *Anthropological Quarterly*

Eisenlohr, Patrick. (2021) Atmospheric Citizenship: Sonic Movement and Public Religion in Shi'i

Mumbai. *Public Culture*

Eshun, Kodwo. (n.d.). Abducted by Audio. http://www.ccru.net/swarm3/3_abducted.htm

Eidsheim, N. S. (2015). Music as Action: Singing Happens before Sound. In *Sensing Sound: Singing and Listening as Vibrational Practice* (pp. 95–131). Duke University Press.

<https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv1220mg3.8>

Grading:

1. **Discussion forums (20%):** Reading responses will be used to evaluate students' comprehension of texts and efforts to engage with readings, films, and sound files uploaded every week. The days reading responses are due are marked on Moodle and will be due the midnight before the day the readings are to be discussed in class. For e.g. If a reading due on Tuesday, the response will need to be turned on Monday night at the latest. Responses will be 200-300 words in total.
2. **Writing Sound (20%):** This assignment will develop on the method **critical listening** and **stop-and-listen** discussed in the class to come up with a descriptive and analytical writing piece (in around 700 words). These writing pieces will describe a subjective experience (a personal experience of an individual) within a physical and affective environment. This assignment may or may not align with the course final project.
3. **Recording Sound (20%):** Students will record clean tracks of five distinct (at least 15 seconds each) types or intersections of sound that have distinct textures and are demonstrative of sonic environments that relate to student's part of the final project. The idea is to explore how to isolate sound types while using digital recorders. At the same time, students will learn to manage how sounds fuse and intersect in physical environments--and how to mitigate these while carrying out recording.
4. **Group presentations (10%):** Groups of students will present one of the featured works in the online project "Machine Listening". These projects will have to engage with artistic interventions into the practice of machine learning and artificial intelligence that has overtaken the field of audio analysis.
5. **Final Feature (30%):** The final project for this course is primarily the creation of a podcast episode that will be part of an anthology of episodes created thematically by the entire group of students. Students will decide based on collective brainstorming what the common theme for the podcast series would be. The key requirement would be to mix different kinds of feature and ambient sounds, along with mood music and voice/speech. This sound feature (aka podcast episode) will consist of rich, layered sounds, and a story that is told with distinct sound, voice, and music elements either recorded or sourced without copyright concerns with credit. Accompanying each episode would be an album art that resonates with the theme but involves creative and artistic expression. Students will aim to upload this episode on a platform of collective choice such as Bandcamp or Soundcloud and will serve as linkable material for their portfolios.

Important Syllabus statement: Based on student response to the course, the readings and assignments are subject to slight changes. The events and dates noted below are subject to modification. All changes will be communication via announcement (on Moodle) and will be delivered to student's email.

Equipment

Editing Suites: The Creative Commons is equipped with computers that can handle the editing needs for this course. It is recommended that you use these computers instead of your personal computers. If you want to use your computers, make sure you get sufficient RAM, storage, and advance access to University Wi-Fi, VPN, and Adobe CC.

Ensure access to Adobe Creative Cloud: You might need to file a ticket with IT or reach out to the instructor to ensure access.

Storage and backup: ***WARNING*** Files from C:\ drive are periodically deleted remotely by IT services and can result in deletion of important files. Make sure you take at least two backups in an external flash drive, hard drive, and/or “the cloud” to save your files. Make sure to periodically back them up after each work session.

Attendance: Attendance is mandatory for this course. Each student has three unexcused absences (no questions asked); this does not apply to consecutive absences. Any more absences will need an explanation and will need to be excused. Please do not send images or medical notes along with emails. If you are unwell with a contagious illness, please stay at home. After three consecutive absences, students will need to schedule a meeting with the instructor so that we are on the same page when you return back to class. It would be great if you can avoid a scenario when you are absent for three or more consecutive sessions.

Email policy: Email is the best place to reach me for any concerns including excused or emergency unexcused absences from scheduled classes. For all other academic questions, I will take 24-48 hours to get back to you during the work week. For assignment related questions, please plan to ask questions prior to the submission date to avoid any last-minute confusion. I will do my best to respond to all emails in a timely manner. However, I would encourage you to consult the syllabus and the course Moodle page before contacting me. If an email is just a notification or intimation (for e.g. I am running a few minutes late), I might not respond to it.

Classroom conduct: This classroom is intended to be a safe space for people from different backgrounds and contexts. Everyone is expected to be respectful and kind to each other, even if you disagree with someone else’s opinions or views. However, hate or discriminatory speech of any kind including racist, homophobic, classist, sexist, among others, will not be tolerated in the classroom.

Tech use: Devices should only be used for the purpose of notetaking and for class activities. In fact, you’d often be unable to work without them. **Texting, or listening to music, online shopping, is not permitted while class is in session.** All rules have exceptions. If you are doing a creative activity while we are in class and need some white noise, music, or even need to leave the space briefly, this can be accommodated. I encourage you to check-in with me for these options!

AI Statement: One thing is for sure: a generative AI software cannot pass this course. As students of digital culture, you understand that AI is a broad category that includes various generations of development in computing technologies. The use of AI and machine learning range from social media feed generation to speech-detection software like Alexa or Siri. We have to be mindful both glorifying or being petrified of using a few new tools, such as those developed by Open AI or Microsoft. This course doesn't ban the use of AI tools that have recently become popular including ChatGPT, Bard, Dall E, Midjourney, Perplexity, and so on. However, their use is **only selectively permitted**, primarily to enhance learning instead of hindering it. In any scenario, using generative AI for completing the entirety of, or majority of, the project or assignment is not permitted; unless the assignment prompt designed specifically asks you to do so. Please consult with the instructor before proceeding if you have any confusion. **Passing off the work of a text, image, sound, or code generator as your own is also not acceptable in any scenario.** If you are using generative AI tools in a part of an assignment, acknowledge the extent of it along with a rationale of 'Why I used AI here' in a short sentence or two before submitting it.

Scenarios where AI use *is* recommended:

- To generate potential ideas as starting points when stuck. These can never be the end of your thought or writing.
- To clarify terms while reading an article. For terms with intellectual histories such as theoretical or philosophical concepts, make sure you double check a reliable source such as an encyclopedia.
- To create a scaffolding for piece of generic writing: For e.g., "Can you tell me what components to include in my final portfolio?"
- Reducing time for web-research/browsing. For e.g., "Can you suggest me three of the most used tools that are used by professionals in the field of video production to host their portfolios?"

Scenarios where AI use *is not* allowed in this course:

- For creating storyboard using software-based generators
- For writing scripts or discussion responses due in class
- For writing reflections or generating discussion questions, takeaway summaries that will be used in class
- For generating an assignment or its draft, or parts thereof, by writing a prompt into text generator

Resources (relevant to the course):

Makerspace: The Makerspace is a collaborative, prototyping workspace in Thompson Library where you can engage in experimentation and learning. You can use the 3D printers, laser cutters, sewing machines, large format printers, and more. Drop in or schedule your appointment here: <https://libraries.coastal.edu/makerspace/workshops#s-lg-box-33371268>

Fab Lab at Edwards: <https://www.coastal.edu/humanities/resources/fablab/>.

How to make an IT-ticket for software or hardware support? <https://www.coastal.edu/forms/studenthelpdeskform/>

Research appointments (at the Thompson Libraries)

Students can schedule research appointments with our liaison librarian (Adam Johnson). Research appointments are meetings with a librarian who can help:

- Narrow your topic by examining current research conversations
- Develop a research strategy to suit your paper or project
- Find quality sources by refining keywords
- Evaluate sources you've already identified
- Get general guidance on academic papers and projects

Research appointments are available to all students. To schedule a research appointment, click this link or go to the Research Appointments Quick Link on the library homepage, select your librarian, a date, and time, and complete the form.

General resources (available to all students):

- CINO pantry (resources for food insecure students): <https://www.coastal.edu/osl/leadership/civicengagement/cinopantry/>
- Counselling center (offers free counselling sessions for students via student health): <https://www.coastal.edu/counseling/>
- Chosen/Preferred name request (contact Dean of Students for a name/pronoun change request): <https://www.coastal.edu/sea/studentresources/chosennamenotification>
- International Student Services (resources and support for international students): <https://www.coastal.edu/internationalstudents/iss/>
- Academic success center (offers tutoring, coaching, and advice on issues like time-management, procrastination, etc.): <https://www.coastal.edu/studentssuccesscenter/>
- Writing Center (offers one-on-one consultation on student writing work): <https://www.coastal.edu/writingcenter/>
- Student Health Services (primary care, prevention and education services): <https://www.coastal.edu/health/>